REQUEST FOR PROPOSALS

First Steps Infant & Toddler Fund: 2027 Request for Proposals

Competitive project and program grant (two-stage) · Letters of inquiry due January 15, 2027

At a glance

Funding: $10,000 to $40,000 per year, for one or two years

Type of support: Project or program support

Term: One or two years, beginning July 1, 2027

Total available: $420,000 in first-year funding

Geographic eligibility: Applicants must serve families who live in Coconino, Yavapai, Navajo, or Apache counties. Priority is given to proposals serving Apache and Navajo counties and rural areas of Coconino County.

Program page: https://hufsa-stack.github.io/cinder-peaks-community-foundation/grants/first-steps-infant-toddler-fund/

About the program

The First Steps Infant & Toddler Fund invests in the first three years of life, when a child's brain develops faster than at any other time. Created in 2014 by a coalition of Flagstaff families and now supported by more than 200 donors, the fund has granted more than $3.4 million to early childhood programs across the region.

The 2027 Request for Proposals reflects the findings of the Foundation's 2026 Northern Arizona Infant Care Gap brief, which found one licensed infant care slot for every five infants in the four-county region. Proposals that add licensed infant and toddler care capacity in Apache and Navajo counties are especially encouraged.

First Steps uses a two-stage process: a short letter of inquiry, followed by an invited full proposal. Organizations may apply to First Steps every year, including in years when they also apply for a Community Impact Grant.

Focus and impact areas

Focus areas: Early Childhood.

We welcome proposals that address one or more of the following impact areas:

- Access to affordable, high-quality infant and toddler care
- Programs for young parents ages 24 and under and their children
- Support for grandparents and kin caregivers raising children under age three
- Training, compensation, and retention of the early childhood workforce
- Prenatal care and reproductive health services for adolescents and young adults
- Policy advocacy and public awareness related to the priorities above

Populations served

- Infants and toddlers from birth to age three
- Expectant and parenting young adults ages 24 and under
- Grandparents and kin caregivers
- Home-based and center-based early childhood educators

Eligibility

Geographic eligibility

Applicants must serve families who live in Coconino, Yavapai, Navajo, or Apache counties. Priority is given to proposals serving Apache and Navajo counties and rural areas of Coconino County.

Who may apply

- Tax-exempt under Section 501(c)(3), a public agency, a federally recognized tribe or tribal program, or a project with a qualified fiscal sponsor
- Serves families living in Coconino, Yavapai, Navajo, or Apache counties
- Proposed work addresses at least one of the six First Steps priorities
- Licensed or certified child care providers must be in good standing with the Arizona Department of Health Services or the applicable tribal licensing authority
- Organizations may submit one letter of inquiry per year

What we do not fund

- Individual child care tuition payments
- Programs serving only children ages four and older
- Capital construction exceeding $15,000 of the request
- Religious instruction

Funding

$10,000 to $40,000 per year, for one or two years. Project or program support.

Key dates

Milestone	Date
Application period opens	Monday, November 2, 2026
Letter of inquiry deadline	Friday, January 15, 2027, 5:00 p.m. MST
Invitations to submit a full application	Sent by January 29, 2027
Full application deadline	Friday, March 5, 2027, 5:00 p.m. MST
Award notification date	Friday, April 16, 2027
Grant period	July 1, 2027 – June 30, 2028 (one-year grants) or June 30, 2029 (two-year grants)

How to apply

First Steps uses a two-stage process. Only organizations invited after the letter of inquiry review may submit a full proposal.

1. **Read the RFP.** Download the First Steps Infant & Toddler Fund 2027 Request for Proposals, which describes priorities, eligibility, and review criteria.
2. **Submit a letter of inquiry.** Complete the Letter of Inquiry Template (two pages maximum) and email it as a PDF to grants@cinderpeakscf.org with the subject line "First Steps LOI – [Organization Name]" by 5:00 p.m. MST on January 15, 2027.
3. **Receive an invitation.** The First Steps Advisory Committee reviews all letters. Invitations to submit a full proposal are sent by January 29, 2027.
4. **Submit the full proposal.** Invited applicants submit the full proposal in the CPCF Grant Portal with a completed Grant Project Budget Template by 5:00 p.m. MST on March 5, 2027.
5. **Decision.** Applicants are notified of award decisions on April 16, 2027, and funds are released in July.

Review criteria

- Alignment with First Steps priorities and documented need
- Number of infants, toddlers, and caregivers served
- Involvement of parents and caregivers in program design
- Strength of partnerships with child care providers, clinics, or tribal programs
- Feasibility of the work plan and budget
- Plan to measure results

Reporting requirements

Grantees submit an interim progress report at six months and a final grant report at the end of each grant year.

- Progress toward the outcomes listed in the approved proposal
- Number of infants, toddlers, parents, and caregivers served, by county
- Budget-to-actual expense report
- Lessons learned and changes to the original plan

Due: Interim report due January 15, 2028; final report due July 31, 2028 (and July 31, 2029 for two-year grants).

Templates and supporting documents

- **Letter of Inquiry Template:** https://hufsa-stack.github.io/cinder-peaks-community-foundation/documents/templates/cpcf-letter-of-inquiry-template.pdf
- **Grant Project Budget Template:** https://hufsa-stack.github.io/cinder-peaks-community-foundation/documents/templates/cpcf-grant-project-budget-template.pdf
- **Interim Progress Report Form:** https://hufsa-stack.github.io/cinder-peaks-community-foundation/documents/reporting/cpcf-interim-progress-report-form.pdf

- **Final Grant Report Form:** https://hufsa-stack.github.io/cinder-peaks-community-foundation/documents/reporting/cpcf-final-grant-report-form.pdf
- **Northern Arizona Infant Care Gap: 2026 Research Brief:** https://hufsa-stack.github.io/cinder-peaks-community-foundation/documents/reports/cpcf-northern-arizona-infant-care-gap-brief-2026.pdf

Frequently asked questions

Can we request two years of funding?

Yes. Two-year requests may be up to $40,000 per year. Second-year funding is released after the Foundation approves the first-year final report.

Do family child care homes qualify?

Licensed or certified family child care homes may apply through a fiscal sponsor or as part of a network led by an eligible organization.

Questions?

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